

LISTENING

#21

1 – Listen to a speaker discussing how English became the dominant global language. Pay attention to the economic reasons for learning languages, the influence of the British Empire, and how English shapes scientific research and opportunities.

The Benefits of Learning English

- 1 - What does the speaker say is the main reason people choose to learn another language?
 - a) Personal interest
 - b) Economic opportunity
 - c) Cultural curiosity
 - 2 - According to the European study, how much can learning a second language increase wages?
 - a) Between 5 and 20 percent
 - b) Between 1 and 5 percent
 - c) Over 30 percent
 - 3 - According to the speaker, what factors have led to the rise of English? (Mark two answers.)

It is easy to learn. ()

It was spread by British colonialism. ()

It gives speakers economic benefits. ()

It is the preferred language for higher education. ()
 - 4 - What expression does John McWhorter use to describe English?
 - a) "A giant step forward"
 - b) "A big fat language"
 - c) "A global necessity"
 - 5 - According to Michael Gordon, what originally helped spread English around the world?
 - a) Technology
 - b) The British Empire
 - c) International trade deals
 - 6 - What additional factor contributed to the rise of English besides colonialism?
 - a) The growth of American power and higher education
 - b) The popularity of English music
 - c) The simplicity of English grammar
 - 7 - What percentage of publications in the elite natural sciences are in English?
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- 8 - What challenge do many non-native scientists face?
 - a) Lack of interest in science
 - b) Difficulty reaching the high level of English required
 - c) Few job opportunities in their countries

Full Name _____

READING COMPREHENSION

The Hidden Inequality Behind the Spread of English

English remains the most common language for international communication, but its dominance is increasingly questioned. According to The Guardian, a large part of its global reach stems from colonial history and modern economic power. Native English speakers number only a small fraction of the world's population, yet their language is used by billions as a second or foreign tongue.

In many countries, English is taught as a compulsory subject, and governments allocate significant portions of their education budgets to this single language. This means that countless learners invest years mastering English, while native speakers benefit without such effort. The article highlights the notion of “linguistic justice” — the idea that communication networks only work fairly if everyone has a similar cost to access them.

The benefits of knowing English are clear: access to better jobs, international travel, science, diplomacy, and global media. Yet the flip side is that other languages and cultures may be devalued. The dominance of English can reinforce inequalities: those who are non-native speakers may struggle with fluency, limiting their full participation in global discourse.

Moreover, when a language becomes so widespread, it can shape the way the world thinks. Local languages and knowledge systems risk being overshadowed, and cultural diversity may shrink. The Guardian argues that while English continues to function as a kind of global bridge, this role comes with trade-offs: fairness, representation, and diversity may suffer.

The future of English is not guaranteed. As power shifts and new technologies emerge, the current linguistic landscape could change. But for now, English continues to be “the world's language”, and with that status comes both opportunity and responsibility.

Retrieved from: <https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2023/dec/27/english-world-power-language-linguistic-justice>

Comprehension Questions

1. According to the text, why might some scientific ideas “go unnoticed”?

2. According to the text, what inequality does the dominance of English create?

3. What risk does the article mention regarding local languages and cultures?

4. Should global communication rely less on English in the future? Explain.
